Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list “green = this”, and yet some meanings repeat surprisingly often. They are usually made up of three layers, **the body**, **culture** and **what we have lived through ourselves**.

From the body

Green is the colour of **grass**, **leaves** and **the forest**. In daylight the human eye is also most sensitive to precisely the yellow-green part of the spectrum. No wonder the body easily links it with what is alive, with water and with shelter. Green says. **Life is possible here.**

Stephen and Rachel Kaplan described the theory that attention is restored in nature. Nothing forces us to concentrate, clouds, leaves and water occupy us gently and concentration rests. Studies show a small but repeatedly observed improvement of mood after time in nature. The evidence is not consistent, though, and it is not clear what role green itself plays, as opposed to quiet, fresh air or movement.

From culture

We give green when someone permits us something. It is the colour of ecology, hope and spring. In the Islamic tradition it is traditionally the colour of paradise. At the same time it is the colour of sickness and envy, “green with envy”, “green as bile”. The same colour can thus mean **hope** and nausea. **It depends on where we grew up.** In the section on cultures we will look at this in more detail.

From what you have lived

Grandmother's garden, the forest you went to as a child, a green school blackboard, a hospital corridor, a waiting room, a green jacket from holidays. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same green** and one of them feels calm, the other tension because someone is about to call her to the board. The colour is the same. The story is not.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is “green” and what is your story about it.

A question for you

“What comes to mind first when I see a woman in a green dress or a man in a green shirt?”

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Stories

Why green means “go”

Today it is taken for granted, but it used to be different. On the railway white meant “clear”, green “caution” and red “stop”. White, however, was often confused with the moon or a lantern. And when a red glass broke, the signal showed white where it should have shown “stop”. That is why white was phased out from the end of the 19th century and green became the signal for “clear”. The first street traffic light with red, yellow and green was introduced in **1920** in Detroit by the policeman **William Potts**. Green thus did not get its permission from nature, but from a technical improvement.

Green with envy

In English they say “green-eyed monster”. It was made famous by **Shakespeare**. In The Merchant of Venice there is “green-eyed jealousy” and in Othello (around 1604) Iago warns of jealousy as a “green-eyed monster”. Perhaps it was helped by the fact that green is associated with illness and with unripe fruit that gives you stomach ache. In Czech it is “green with envy”. Envy is usually unpleasant, but it often shows what you long for.

The green that killed

In **1775** the Swedish chemist **Carl Wilhelm Scheele** produced a rich green pigment containing arsenic. In the 19th century it was put into wallpaper and dresses because it was cheap and beautifully fresh. Arsenic, however, is poisonous. It is said that arsenic from damp wallpaper may have contributed to the death of Napoleon on Saint Helena. That is not proven, it is disputed. All that is certain is that fashion sometimes hurts.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.